

§5 Solution Sketch — Inclusion / Exclusion Checklist

Day 1 · Activity 4 handout. §5 is the most-mis-written PRD section. Describe the solution *just enough* for an engineer to imagine its shape — not so much that you've designed it for them. Use this checklist while drafting, then run the "engineer's first three questions" test.

✓ What goes IN §5

- ☐ The **user-visible flow** — 4–8 steps from the user's perspective.
- ☐ The **key surfaces** affected (which screens, which surfaces).
- ☐ The **hard interactions** with other systems (other products, APIs, third parties — name them).
- ☐ A **happy-path narrative** — one paragraph describing what a successful run looks like.
- ☐ (*Optional, encouraged*) 1–2 simple sketches or wireframes.

✗ What stays OUT of §5

- ☐ Database schema decisions
- ☐ Specific API contracts
- ☐ Class names, framework choices, library picks
- ☐ Pixel-level layout

The "engineer's first three questions" test

After writing §5, each triad member proposes the **first three questions** an engineer would ask after reading it. Then diagnose:

IF THE QUESTIONS ARE ABOUT...	YOUR §5 IS...	DO THIS
Implementation choice (which DB? which framework?)	Over-specified — you've designed it for them	Pull back; leave room for engineering judgment
User behavior or scope (what if the user does X? is Y in scope?)	Correctly specified	Good — those are the right questions
Basic mechanics ("what does this even do?")	Under-specified	Add the missing flow step or surface

Common failure mode: most over-specifications come from PMs who used to be engineers. If your three questions are all implementation questions, you've over-specified — cut back.

Triad three-questions capture

MEMBER	Q1	Q2	Q3	OVER / UNDER / OK?
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